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Behind the Scenes: Enhancing UX in a B2B System within the Media Industry

A Research through Design Study

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Swedish subtitle: En Research through Design studie

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The media industry relies on complex Business-to-Business (B2B) platforms to manage and distribute content. While these systems are critical, their interfaces have historically received less attention than Business-to-Customer (B2C) products, resulting in usability challenges that directly affect efficiency and introduce risk when handling sensitive material. This study investigates how navigation within ClipSource's system *Media Center* can be improved for its users. Furthermore it provides a reflection on how AI tools can support the design process. Using a Research through Design approach, structured by elements of Design Thinking to guide the user-centered process, the study utilises semi-structured interviews, iterative prototyping, cognitive walkthroughs, and evaluation with professionals within the media industry. The study suggests that effective B2B user experience (UX) design should accommodate both novice and advanced users through clear information hierarchy, embedded guidance, and considered aesthetics, rather than simply minimising complexity, as users in the media industry demonstrate a relatively high tolerance for learning curves.

SAMMANFATTNING

Medieindustrin är beroende av komplexa Business-to-Business (B2B) plattformar för att hantera och distribuera innehåll. Även om dessa system är kritiska har deras gränssnitt historiskt sett fått mindre uppmärksamhet än Business-to-Customer (B2C) produkter, vilket har resulterat i användbarhetsutmaningar som direkt påverkar effektiviteten och introducerar risker vid hantering av känsligt material. Denna studie undersöker hur navigeringen inom ClipSources system *Media Center* kan förbättras för dess användare. Vidare ger den en reflektion kring hur AI-verktyg kan stödja designprocessen. Genom att använda Research through Design, kombinerat med inslag av Design Thinking för att vägleda den användarcentrerade processen, använder studien semistrukturerade intervjuer, iterativ prototypframtagning, kognitiva genomgångar och utvärdering tillsammans med yrkesverksamma inom medieindustrin. Studien tyder på att effektiv B2B user experience (UX) bör anpassas för både nybörjare och avancerade användare genom en tydlig informationshierarki, inbyggd vägledning och genomtänkt visuell design, snarare än att enbart minimera komplexitet, eftersom användare inom mediebranschen har en relativt hög tolerans för inlärningskurvor.

CCS Concepts: • **Human-centered computing** → **User interface design**; *Usability testing*; *User studies*; Interaction design; Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords: Human-Computer Interaction, UX-design, B2B

Nyckelord: Människa-datorinteraktion, UX-design, B2B

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1 INTRODUCTION

The media industry not only entertains us, it shapes who we are [18, 21, 51]. Taking such a central part of our lives, it is unsurprising that over 9000 films are produced annually [49] and that Subscription Video on Demand (SVOD) services reach over 1.5 billion users worldwide [45]. What most viewers never consider, however, is what happens before any of that content reaches them. Prior to release, media is routinely distributed to journalists for review. By doing so, media houses can get an indication of how well a film will perform and use this as advertisement [4, 19]. This is where ClipSource comes in. With their systems, media companies can easily manage and distribute their content before a release, everything from press releases to screeners, making it possible for journalists to easily take part of that information. This requires a safe and efficient system, which ensure that no unreleased content will be leaked.

While ClipSource's platform has been developed in close collaboration with its users, the interface has seen limited updates since its initial release. For Business-to-Business (B2B) users, this matters more than it might for Business-to-Customer (B2C) users. Unlike consumer-facing platforms, where poor navigation causes frustration, in a B2B context it directly impacts work efficiency and can introduce risk when handling sensitive, unreleased material. Yet most existing UX research focuses on consumer-facing interfaces, leaving internal and B2B tools within the media industry comparatively understudied. Furthermore, the role of Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools in the design process itself remains an emerging area of research (see Section 2).

This study investigates how navigation within ClipSource's *Media Center* can be improved for its B2B users and proposes a redesign. Furthermore it reflects on how AI tools can support the design process. Building on UX-design methods, this study addresses the following research question:

- What interface characteristics support both novice and advanced users in navigating a B2B system within the media industry?

2 BACKGROUND

This section introduces previous research on UX design, followed by specific B2B design principles, as well as an introduction to ClipSource and *Media Center*, and lastly previous research on AI as a tool in the design process.

2.1 UX-design

Investing time in enhancing a website's usability is a strategic business decision that strengthens competitiveness and can delivers strong returns [34]. Within the field of User-Experience (UX) design, decades of research have resulted in a wide range of proposed guidelines and conceptual frameworks (e.g. [36, 38, 43]). A significant focus has also been placed on accessibility, where standards such as ISO [17] and WCAG [12] play a central role in designing websites that are accessible to a wide range of users. These UX theories are grounded in psychological principles connected to perception, memory and information processing [50], which in turn affect motivation [48]. Consequently, factors such as information structure and familiarity are continuously highlighted as fundamental pillars to ensure usability [50]. However, balancing principles in practice can be challenging. From psychology research, we are familiar with the paradox of choice: too few options can feel restrictive, while too many can feel overwhelming and demotivating [25, 42]. In addition, there are also inherent trade-offs between simplicity, which is often

perceived as making something easier to use, and complexity, which is often perceived as more functional but less user friendly [15].

Many enterprise systems face significant usability challenges today, largely due to their complexity and the overwhelming amount of information they provide. These factors often lead to user frustration, particularly among novices. Additionally, systems of this kind typically have a steep learning curve, as they offer minimal guidance [13]. Despite these clear understandings from exsiting research, often systems still exhibit substandard UX. There are many systematic challenges within an organisation that results in human-centered design not being prioritised. For instance, not knowing the value of good UX, lack of iteration in development or lack of research concerning specific target users. There can also be internal disputes and divided vision among the team leading to poor UX being implemented [20]. Even if accessibility is generally thought of in development, research indicates that a lack of time and knowledge often lead to limited implementation [24]. Consequently, iterative usability testing throughout the development is an essential part of the UX design process [5, 20, 22, 30].

2.2 B2B versus B2C

How a system should be designed differs between B2B and B2C contexts, as the user groups have different needs and goals. In B2C contexts users can easily switch to competitors, making it crucial to capture and retain their attention. Additionally, purchasing decisions are often influenced by emotional factors, and design efforts therefore tend to focus on ease of use, visual aesthetics, privacy, and accessibility [8, 29].

In contrast, B2B systems are typically more strongly shaped by functional decision-making [29]. These systems often contain larger amounts of information and greater levels of detail [14, 29]. In this case functionality is prioritised over aesthetics [8], as research indicates that aesthetics does not necessarely increase efficiency [37]. While an aesthetic-usability effect might be temporary [44], clarity [14] and a well-structured hierarchy of information support effective and efficient information retrieval in B2B contexts in a sustained manner [29]. Furthermore, each system page should have a clear primary purpose and use clear language [14].

Beyond clarity and functionality, research has shown that informativeness plays a significant role in B2B systems effectiveness [8, 9], alongside organization, personalization, and interactivity [8]. Although onboarding is important for complex systems [52], B2B systems should be sufficiently intuitive to allow users to learn through exploration, without the need for extensive instructions [14]. Organisational support further plays an important role, and regularly collecting user feedback on system usability is considered best practice [29]. However, during evaluation it has been observed that employees tend to compare B2B systems with B2C systems, which are typically more user-friendly, resulting in lower overall ratings [27].

Differences also exist between user groups within B2B contexts. B2B systems operating in culturally diverse environments should not be designed as universal solutions, as cultural factors influence which aspects users prioritise. For example, European users tend to place strong emphasis on information quality, whereas North American users highly value usability. One possible explanation for this difference is that North American users often experience greater time constraints [9].

Finally, it has been argued that developers of B2B systems carry a particular responsibility. Designers must balance business goals with user needs, as decisions made by the company providing the system can have significant consequences for users across multiple client organisations [41].

2.3 ClipSource and Media Center

ClipSource is a B2B company in the media industry focusing on public relations (PR), catering to clients such as SVT, Warner Bros. Discovery, and Storytel. They provide products with a broad range of functionalities, from managing metadata to distributing content to stakeholders.

Within the scope of this research, ClipSource's product *Media Center* (see Figure 1 and Figure 2) will be evaluated and redesigned. The primary users are journalists and media companies, and the system is used differently between these groups. For media companies, the platform allows users to write, manage, and publish posts, including scheduling releases, as well as control access to determine who can view specific content. For journalists, the platform allows them to access press releases and media content, to be able to write articles about the material.

It primarily functions by automatically retrieving data from organizations' internal systems. ClipSource's customers indicate structure, clarity and predictability of that content as main areas to tackle to ensure a smooth and efficient experience. To complicate matters, not all users have access to the same material, which means that the interface is presented in many different ways.

In this project several techniques and tools will be utilised to develop a design proposal. Additioanlly, a reflection on the new possibilities offered by AI in this area will be produced.

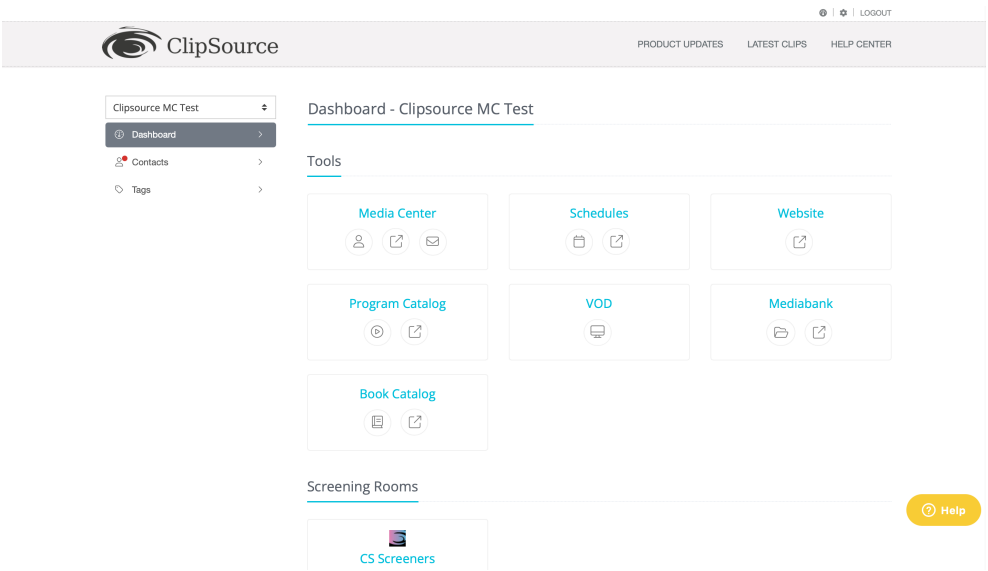


Figure 1: ClipSource dashboard.

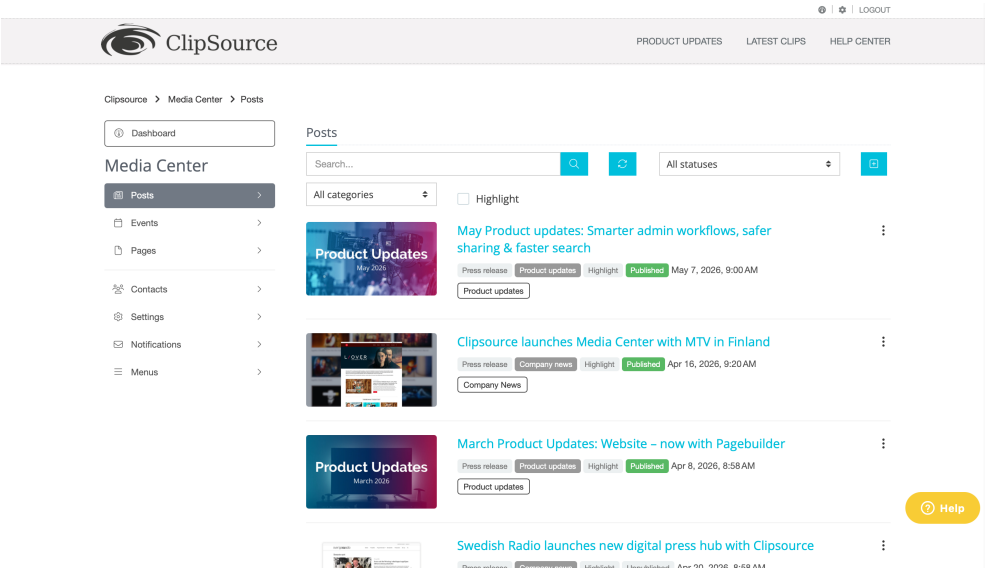


Figure 2: Media Center posts view.

2.4 AI as a Design Tool

AI can be applied at nearly every stage of the design process, ranging from user research to generating design ideas [2]. Current research shows that AI appears to deliver the greatest value in early-stage activities such as market and product research [53], and early development tasks like wireframe creation. In contrast, non-AI tools may be more beneficial in later stages of product development [31]. Across studies, there is consensus that AI enhances creativity, quality, and efficiency when used as a tool or collaborator in design [10, 31, 33, 53].

Although most research highlights the benefits of integrating AI into the design process, its use also presents several challenges. Bias in training datasets may lead to biased design outcomes [10, 33]. AI tools such as ChatGPT do not always successfully complete design related tasks, and effective prompting can be challenging. In some cases, the quality of AI-generated designs is insufficient, reducing efficiency when revisions are required. Furthermore, AI systems may produce misinformation and hallucinations [33, 53], highlighting the importance of critical thinking. Lastly, due to their black-box nature, the reasoning behind generated solutions is often unclear, in contrast to human designers who can justify their decisions by drawing on experience and user insights [33, 46].

3 METHOD

This section provides insight into the methods and structure of the study, including interviews, analysis, prototyping, and evaluation. The target participants (users of the system) and ethical considerations are also discussed.

3.1 Study Design

Research through Design (RtD) [54] uses the process of designing artefacts as a method for generating knowledge about complex design problems. This approach is appropriate for the present study, as the prototype for Clipsource's *Media Center* serves as an exploration of how B2B systems can be designed.

Elements of Design Thinking (DT) [7] are incorporated within the RtD framework to structure the user-centered design process. DT typically consists of three main phases: an initial inspiration phase, in which the problem space is explored, which in this study is based on a pre-study and interviews; an ideation phase, where design concepts are developed through sketches and prototypes and subsequently evaluated through user testing; and finally, an implementation phase in which final decisions are realized. This project focuses on the first two phases (see Figure 3), as the primary aim is to generate knowledge about B2B system design. ClipSource may choose to implement the proposed solutions at a later stage, but implementation is outside the scope of this research. While Figure 3 illustrates the process as structured for ease of comprehension, the actual process involved more fluid movement between stages.

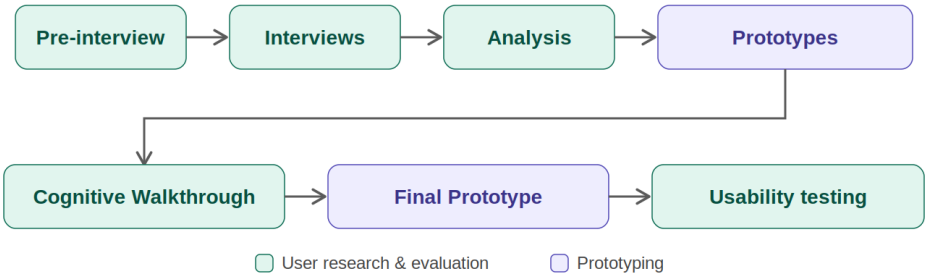


Figure 3: Overview of the research process.

3.2 Pre-interview

Before the interviews were conducted, the participants had the opportunity to reflect over a few statements, connected to issues they may encounter in their everyday work using *Media Center*. Although fully voluntary, participants were encouraged to quickly reflect, but preferably write down, issues or thoughts about the system, as it can be difficult to come up with examples on the spot. They were provided with these instructions via email at the latest two days before the interview.

3.3 Interviews

Semi-structured interviews were then conducted, lasting approximately 45 minutes to an hour each. During the interviews, participants had access to the *Media Center* system to support discussion and as a reference point. Interviews were held in person at ClipSource's office or at the participants' company's office. Interviews were audio-recorded in its entirety, furthermore instances were participants demonstrated using *Media Center* were video recorded.

To ensure an effective interview, factors such as question relevance, the use of clear language, and question order [47] were considered. The interview was structured into the following stages: introduction, general questions, specific *Media Center* questions, and finally a closing question. To ensure that all relevant questions were asked, a pilot interview with a ClipSource employee was conducted. Pen and paper were provided to be able to sketch out ideas, if participants wanted to do so.

3.4 Analysis

In preparation for the analysis, the interview recordings were transcribed using Klang [28] and then manually corrected. The results were analysed through a thematic analysis based on Braun's and Clarke's framework [6]. The analyses were conducted in several stages, beginning with familiarisation of the material, moving into finding and reviewing themes.

3.5 Prototypes

Based on the insights from the interviews, three prototypes were developed. The design process was iterative, with multiple design concepts explored. In this stage Claude [3] and ChatGPT [39] were used to brainstorm possible design ideas. Low-fidelity prototypes were initially created through sketches, followed by the development of high-fidelity designs in Figma [16].

3.6 Cognitive Walkthrough

Three prototypes were evaluated using a cognitive walkthrough [40], in which participants completed specific tasks to uncover potential issues. The focus was on how users interact with, explore, and learn the system. As the employees know their clients well, valuable perspectives could be provided from them about the design recommendations, which offered the opportunity to validate the design decisions made to improve the system. After performing each task, they were able to openly talk about their opinions about the changes made.

3.7 Final Prototype

After analysing the results from the cognitive walkthrough, a final prototype was developed. This was done by firstly illustrating the design in Figma. Then the prototype was programmed using HTML, CSS and JavaScript. This was done in Visual Studio (VS) Code using Github copilot for quick iterations. When the prototype was done, it was deployed using Github pages.

3.8 Usability testing

The final usability testing was conducted in two stages. In the first stage, the prototype was sent out along with instructions and a questionnaire, inspired by the User Experience Questionnaire (UEQ). Themes included in the prototype were: Attractiveness, Efficiency, Perspicuity, Aesthetics, Adaptability, and Clarity. All questions were structured so that participants could compare the current prototype with the original product. After each section, they had the opportunity to add comments if they wished to clarify their answers. At the end of the questionnaire, they were asked to reflect on the prototype they had just reviewed.

During the second stage of the evaluation, users had the opportunity to participate in a final interview (maximum 20 minutes), aimed to gather deeper insight into what they liked, disliked, or felt was missing from the prototype. The interviews were semi-structured and mainly focused on navigation within the system.

3.9 Participants

The criterion for participant inclusion was regular use of *Media Center*. Participants for the user interviews and final evaluation were employed by media companies (e.g. SVT and TV4) and their experience of the system ranged from under a year to over ten years. The participants in the final evaluation had also

taken part in the initial user interviews. Participants for the cognitive walkthroughs were employed at ClipSource. Five participants took part in the interviews, four in the cognitive walkthrough, and three participated in the final evaluation.

4 RESULTS

This section presents the qualitative findings from user interviews, the cognitive walkthrough, and the evaluation in chronological order. Quotes from participants (P) and employees (E) are indicated with their respective letters.

4.1 User interviews

Analysis of the user interviews revealed eight themes: navigation, unity, consistency, language, information, learning, aesthetics, and control. The following sections present these themes in related groupings.

Navigation. A key finding was that efficient navigation is not just reducing the number of steps, but reducing clutter. Further, more navigation options do not necessarily lead to better navigation, and a shorter path to a destination is not always the route users naturally take. Participants therefore indicated that a less cluttered interface could be a higher priority than minimising the number of clicks, even if this results in slightly more complex navigation. This could for example be observed when participants navigated to the front-end of *Media Center*. Instead of using the shortcut buttons, most users navigated through their browser.

A related issue was the lack of system-wide search functionality, which created redundancies in users' workflows. Without the ability to search across the whole system, one user expressed that they were forced to move through multiple modules to locate and remove the same item, an unnecessary and frustrating extra step. P2 explained this:

> "Our picture editor got in touch with me and said that there is an image in our service that we are not allowed to publish. We must remove it. There are three of the same image. Then I searched for it and could see what image she meant. But the reason that it existed three times, that is when you searched you got up this image, but you got it up as three results. It was because it was located in three different places. One of them was in our media bank. One of them was as an episode image in our program catalogue. And one of them was in some third place, maybe as a related media to, a post in media center."

In addition, participants expressed a preference for fewer pages when creating posts. Hierarchy emerged as an additional sub-theme within navigation. While the system contains a wide range of functionalities, most users only engage with a small subset of them on a regular basis:

> "My colleagues only use this. They post and write press releases. That's the only thing they do. Then sometimes, every once in a while, they go into contacts to, just like me, accept an access request." (P1)

This suggests that restructuring the content hierarchy, prioritising the most frequently used functions, could significantly improve the efficiency for the majority of users.

Unity, Consistency, and Language. Participants expressed that the system's dashboard, composed of separated modules, lacked a sense of unity. Rather than feeling like a single cohesive system, the interface came across as a collection of disconnected tools. Beyond the overall fragmented feel, inconsistency in smaller details, such as button labels and wording varying across different parts of the system, added to

participants' uncertainty. This is particularly relevant in this context, because unclear language made users hesitant about whether certain actions were safe to perform. Given that much of the content managed in the system is sensitive and cannot be distributed before a set date, any ambiguity around publishing actions carries real risk. One participant recounted such an experience:

> "It has happened a couple of times that we have sent duplicate emails. And it's not the end of the world, but it's a bit sloppy to send two emails at the same second. So it's a bit annoying. Because it's clearly there, it is set up. I don't understand why it's not visible to me that I have set it up." (P2)

This illustrates how inconsistent language is not merely a cosmetic issue, it can directly disrupt workflows and undermine users' trust in the system's feedback.

Information and Learning. Given the complexity of the system, guiding users effectively is a central concern. Participants noted that working with multiple systems is common in the media industry, meaning users are generally accustomed to onboarding processes, which in turn raises their tolerance for a learning curve in a B2B context. P1 reflected this view:

> "Which in the TV industry in Sweden, the media industry in Sweden, then you change jobs very, very often. And everyone has different systems for everything. Whether it is news databases or if it is publishing tools for radio or for TV or internal systems for communication. If one has changed jobs once a year for 15 years then one is very used to that okay how does this system work? Then one takes a day or two and then one is into it."

During one interview session, a participant encountered an error when attempting to crop an image, receiving only the message "*something went wrong*". The participant was unable to recover from this on their own, highlighting the need for more descriptive and actionable error feedback. Another participant expressed a similar issue regarding feedback when publishing a post:

> "And then I went into it and didn't really understand at first how I was supposed to look. Because then it goes directly to publish there. And for me it becomes like this, I get really stressed. That I might accidentally publish something that I'm not allowed to publish." (P3)

More broadly, while participants valued the direct organisational support offered by ClipSource, it was noted that needing to contact the company to resolve uncertainties was not always ideal. In-system guidance was seen as a preferable addition. This reinforces the broader finding that guidance should be embedded in the interface itself, through clearer labels, contextual explanations, and meaningful error messages, rather than relying on external support. Furthermore, participants indicated that the current placement of product update information is not ideal. When a user opens the system, their intent is to complete a task, not to read new feature announcements. Participants found it sufficient to receive this type of information via email instead as they check their inbox regularly.

Aesthetics. Visual design (in this study focusing primarily on color) was a meaningful concern for participants. Research findings suggest that aesthetics do not need to be a primary focus, but an interface that feels current and visually balanced contributes positively to the overall user experience. Participants were not looking for bold or striking visuals, rather colors should remain non-distracting. However, the current interface was perceived as outdated and visually flat.

Control. A recurring point raised by participants was that editing pages and posts within the system was more difficult than it needed to be. This was showcased in *Pages*, where making precise changes requires

the use of HTML code. Most of the users who interact with this system do not have technical knowledge, and therefore a significant portion of users are effectively locked out of this functionality. Participants pointed to more intuitive alternatives, such as drag-and-drop interactions in *Media Center*, as a preferred direction. This would lower the learning barrier and allow a broader range of users to engage confidently with the system.

4.2 Prototypes

Based on the findings from the user interviews, the first prototype was developed to address the identified usability issues and design concerns (see Figure 4 and Figure 5).

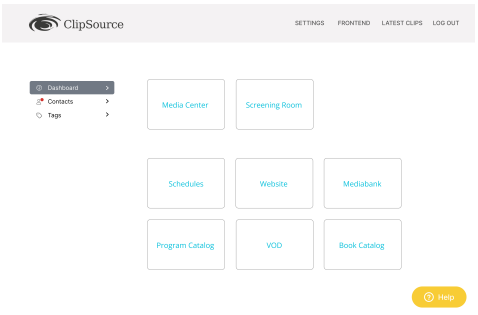


Figure 4: Dashboard - Addressing main issues raised in the user interviews

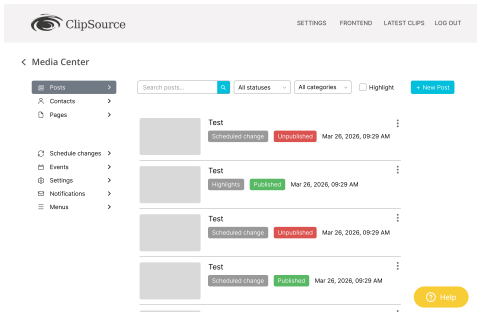


Figure 5: Posts - Addressing main issues raised in the user interviews

The second prototype was developed as an extension of the first, further addressing visual design by incorporating color and accessibility considerations (see Figure 6 and Figure 7).

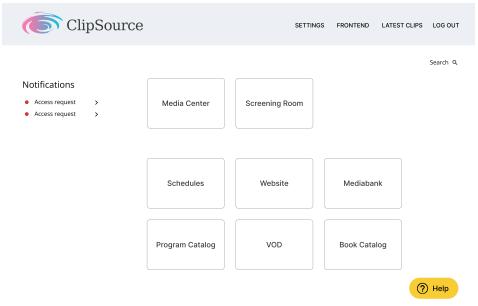


Figure 6: Dashboard - Updated visual design and accessibility improvements

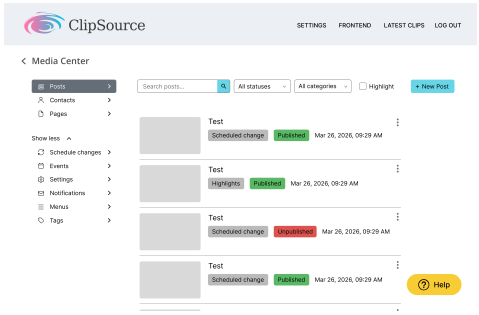


Figure 7: Posts - Updated visual design and accessibility improvements

The third prototype was developed as an extension of the first, with a focus on creating a more unified system (see Figure 8).

4.3 Cognitive Walkthrough

Based on the three prototypes tested with ClipSource employees, eight themes were identified: accessibility, aesthetics, guiding, technical constraints, navigation, hierarchy, complexity, and information. These are presented below in related groupings.

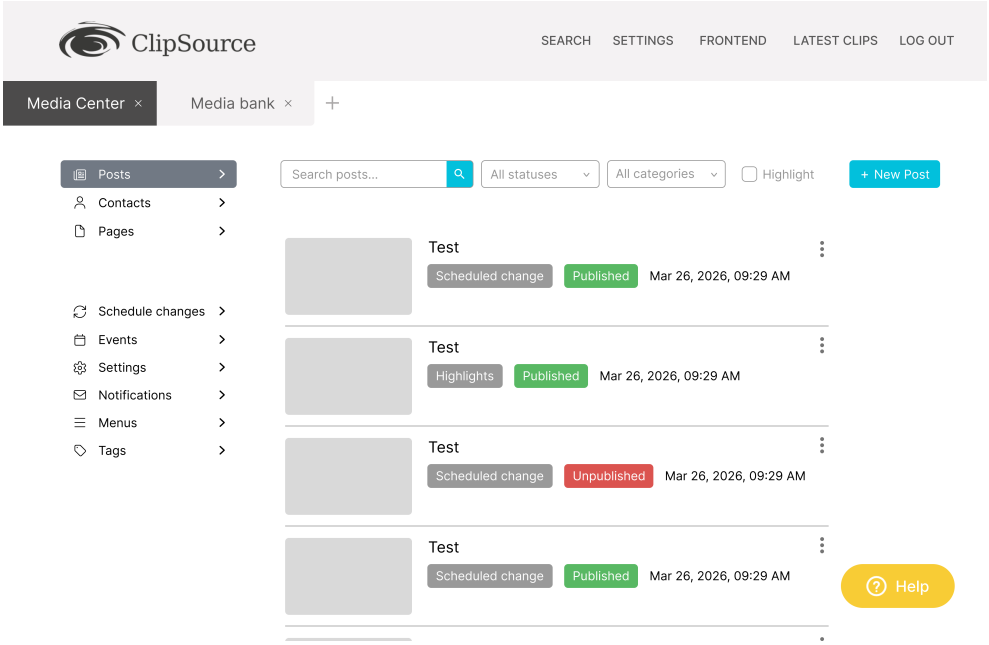


Figure 8: The dashboard was removed and modules were combined into a single interface.

Accessibility and Aesthetics. Aesthetics and accessibility have not been a primary focus in ClipSource's system design. It was noted that while accessibility considerations, specifically in alignment with WCAG guidelines, have been applied to the front-end facing page, the same level of attention has not been extended to the admin interface used by the participants in this study. However, it was noted to be a valuable addition to the system. Further, consistent with findings from the earlier user interviews, aesthetics emerged as a meaningful consideration during the prototype walkthrough. Prototype 2 (see Figure 6 and Figure 7) was particularly appreciated for its use of color. This suggests that even subtle uses of color can contribute positively to the perceived quality of the interface, reinforcing the earlier finding that an up-to-date and visually considered design is an important part of the user experience. Notably:

> "It shouldn't be things that take focus away from what they do every day. Because that is the most important thing for the customer." (E1)

Guiding. The question of how much in-system guidance to provide was a nuanced one among ClipSource employees. On one hand, there was a clear desire to maintain strong organisational support as a defining characteristic of the company's offering. On the other hand, employees suggested that the current system already performs reasonably well in terms of intuitiveness. These two perspectives are not necessarily in conflict. The emerging view was that in-system guidance, such as tips and contextual help, could serve as a valuable complement to the existing support, rather than replacing it. This positions embedded guidance as an enhancement to the user experience without undermining the human support that ClipSource sees as a competitive strength.

Technical constraints. While certain design directions were received positively in theory, employees acknowledged the practical limitations of implementing them. Inline editing tools, for example, were considered an appealing concept, but were deemed unfeasible given the technical architecture of the

system. The challenge lies in the fact that content displayed on a page is often pulled from multiple different sources, making visual, in-place editing difficult to achieve in practice. This is an important consideration when evaluating prototype feedback more broadly, not all desirable design solutions are technically viable, and findings from the walkthrough need to be interpreted with these constraints in mind.

Navigation and Hierarchy. The removal of the dashboard, as implemented in prototype 3 (see Figure 8), was broadly welcomed by employees as a positive step toward a cleaner and more focused interface. However, opinions were more mixed when it came to the specific navigation structure proposed. Presenting modules as tabs was met with scepticism, with a side dropdown menu being seen as a preferable alternative. The question of how to structure the hierarchy of such a menu was also discussed, and it became clear that there is no single obvious solution. Regarding prototype 2 specifically, the notification system was found to be unclear, reinforcing that some form of persistent menu remains necessary for users to orient themselves within the system.

The concept of a global search function was viewed positively by most participants. Notably, a similar feature had been introduced previously but saw limited usage. However, this was not interpreted as a sign that the feature lacked value. A participant suggested that global search may be rarely needed but highly valued when it is.

Another clear finding from the walkthrough was that certain functions, specifically *tags* and *contacts*, should not be tied to individual modules but remain accessible from anywhere within the system. The importance of this global accessibility was widely acknowledged, as these functions are relevant across multiple contexts and workflows. However, there was also some uncertainty among employees about the prioritisation of these functions within the navigation structure. It was questioned by an employee why these functions held such a prominent position. Meanwhile, another pointed to a related consideration around where *admin users* should be placed. These perspectives reflect an ongoing discussion about hierarchy and placement within the navigation structure. The consensus was that global functions should be universally reachable, but exactly where and how prominently remains an open design question.

Complexity. A key change introduced in the prototypes was fewer steps in creating posts, reduced from five steps to three. While the reduction in steps was generally appreciated, and the decision to combine *Posts* with *Related Media* and *Access Control* with *Distribution* was seen as a positive move, it also raised a concern. With fewer steps comes more information presented at once, and one employee questioned whether concentrating that much content into a single view could itself become overwhelming for users. The challenge is therefore not simply to minimise the number of steps, but to find the right balance between steps and clarity.

Information. In the current system, information about new features and updates is surfaced in multiple places, primarily through the dashboard. The prototypes explored an alternative approach, presenting new functionality locally, at the point in the system where it is actually relevant, rather than in a centralised location. This was received positively, with employees seeing contextual, in-place information as more useful than broad announcements. One employee elaborated on this direction:

> "And then I also think, since we can make an adjustment here, or there. Then it's never fair to show somewhere else how things work. Or what has been updated. It's better to almost point to it. Here we have. This is new. Click here to learn more. And try to be quite brief in

the text. But maybe even in some cases fit the entire update in this toast. That would be incredibly good." (E1)

The ability to hide unused information was also highlighted as a desirable feature, with most employees responding positively to this idea. Together, these findings point toward a preference for a more adaptive and contextual information architecture, one that respects the user's focus by surfacing relevant information at the right time and place. The importance of feeling secure when performing high-stakes actions within the system was raised as a consideration during the walkthrough. Publishing a post, for example, was identified as a moment where users need clear confirmation that they are proceeding intentionally. A two-step publishing flow was suggested as a way to provide this reassurance, prompting users to confirm their action before it is finalised.

4.4 Final Prototype

Based on feedback from the cognitive walkthrough and insights from the user interviews, the three prototypes were combined into a final prototype. The changes included improvements to navigation, unity, and visual design (see Figure 9).

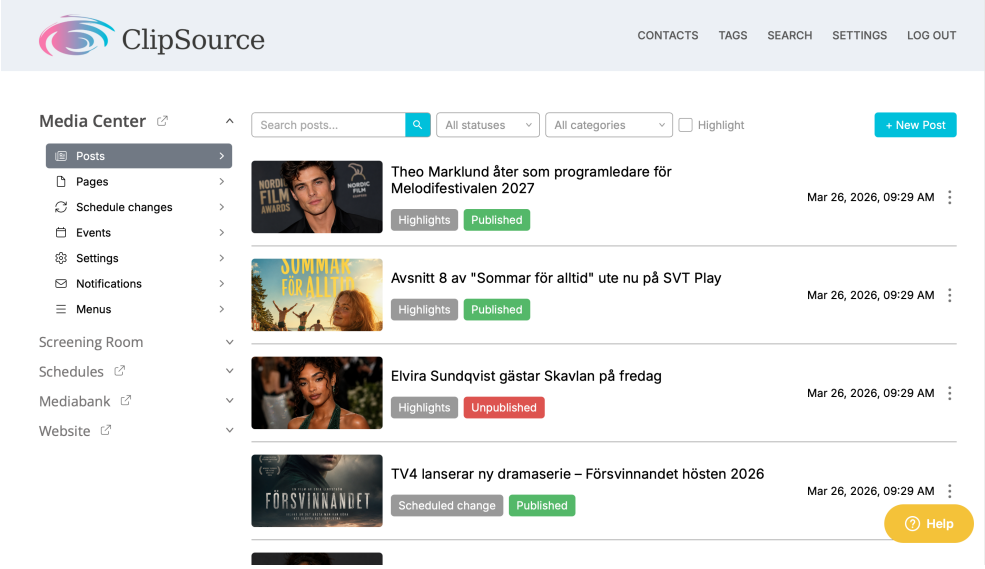


Figure 9: Following the cognitive walkthrough, preferred features from the three prototypes were combined. Images and information are placeholders and do not represent real content.

4.5 Evaluation

Questionnaire. The results indicate that the prototype shows improvements over the current product across all aspects. The largest difference could be seen in the Attractiveness, Efficiency, Perspicuity, and Aesthetics of the prototype, where participants indicated it was better or much better than the original product. In two aspects, Adaptability and Flexibility (Clarity), the prototype was rated the same or better than the original product.

Based on the questionnaire, participants described their initial experiences with the prototype. Overall, participants responded positively to the prototype and perceived it as cleaner, simpler, and easier to

use than the existing solution. They appreciated the replacement of the dashboard with a dropdown menu. Participants also valued the reduction in the number of steps required for editing and publishing content. Additional improvements that were highlighted included the option to keep posts highlighted for a specified period, the clearer separation between scheduling and publishing actions, increased readability through larger text, and enhanced visual design. While one participant noted that the "New Post" button could be more prominent, no participants identified any deteriorations compared to the original product.

User interviews. From the interviews a few insights were highlighted. Overall it was indicated that the prototype was preferred over the original product. Findings showed that participants identified improved visibility, more efficient navigation, and better placement of functions as strengths of the prototype. This was discussed in relation to a function for highlighting posts, as illustrated by one participant:

> "I have been annoyed that this feature hasn't existed at all, but now I have learned in this conversation that it actually has existed, just that I haven't found it." (P2)

Participants further indicated a preference for reducing the number of steps, even if this increased the amount of information presented per page. This was reflected in the merging of two steps when creating a post. Additionally, participants preferred landing directly on posts, as these were identified as the most frequently used tool, making this approach more efficient. The hierarchy of elements was also appreciated, for example the placement of global functions in the header. However, it was indicated that there are areas in which the prototype could benefit from further development. For example, they suggested that some menu items currently found in *Settings* should be moved to a separate menu, distinct from account settings.

> "I would look for my settings, that is my account, my notifications and settings for the account such as *contact cards* and *admin-user* in different places. It is not natural for me that they are in the same place." (P2)

Participants noted that the guide could be useful, but that its current placement made it unlikely they would have found it. They therefore suggested that it should be made more visible within the system. All participants further expressed that the accessibility settings were appreciated, even if they were unsure whether they would use them themselves. P4 and P5 also commented that the increased use of color was better than in the original product.

5 DISCUSSION

The purpose of this study was to explore more efficient navigational opportunities in ClipSource's product *Media Center*, with the research questions: *What interface characteristics support both novice and advanced users in navigating a B2B system within the media industry?*

Findings indicate that novice and advanced users prioritize different aspects of the system. More experienced users tend to engage with a wider range of functionalities, whereas novice users interact with a limited subset, underscoring the importance of a clear information hierarchy that can support both groups. Furthermore, while guiding elements are necessary for novice users, excessive information on the page risks becoming a source of distraction for more experienced users, further emphasizing the role of information architecture in accommodating users across varying levels of system knowledge. Additionally, color emerged as a recurring theme, suggesting that visual design carries more weight in B2B contexts than existing literature typically acknowledges.

In this section, the results will be critically discussed alongside the chosen methodology, before closing with directions for future research.

5.1 Findings

The findings of this study both confirm and contrast with existing frameworks for B2B UX design. In line with prior research, participants consistently prioritized functionality, clarity, and information structure over visual aesthetics, reinforcing the established view that B2B systems are shaped primarily by task-oriented needs [8, 14, 29]. The removal of the dashboard in favor of a structured side menu, for instance, was broadly welcomed not because it looked better, but because it made the system more navigable. This suggests that the core principles identified in B2B UX research transfer to the media industry context, even if that industry has received comparatively little direct attention in the literature. However, the findings also challenge the assumption that aesthetics are largely irrelevant in B2B contexts. Participants in this study actively described the current interface as outdated and dull, and responded positively to even subtle uses of color in the prototype. In the final evaluation, participants even pointed out that more color could be used. This suggests that aesthetics in B2B may serve a functional role, a dimension that existing frameworks do not fully account for. B2B users may evaluate their work tools against the more polished consumer-facing interfaces they encounter in daily life [27]. This puts increasing pressure on B2B designers to close the gap, not by mimicking B2C design, but by adopting a level of intentionality and polish that has historically been seen as unnecessary in the context of B2B systems.

The findings further indicate that B2B systems must accommodate both novice users who need guidance and experienced users who prioritize efficiency. The system must further accommodate professionals whose broad range of responsibilities necessitates access to extensive system functionality, while simultaneously supporting professionals whose work requires only a limited subset of functions, without compromising usability for either group. In this study, the redesign addressed this by restructuring the content hierarchy around the most frequently used functions while preserving access to advanced features through a persistent side menu. Participants also emphasized the importance of customizability, suggesting that further development of adaptive and customizable interface elements could enhance the system's overall usability.

Participants indicated that working across multiple systems is a natural part of the media industry. As a result, users appeared comparatively tolerant of a learning curve and did not necessarily expect the same simplicity commonly associated with B2C systems. This suggests that some degree of complexity may be acceptable, or even expected, in B2B environments when that complexity enables users to perform advanced or specialised tasks. The findings therefore reinforce the notion that usability in B2B systems should not be understood solely as minimising complexity, but rather as structuring complexity in a way that remains predictable, learnable, and efficient over time. In this context, participants did not advocate for fewer functions, but for clearer hierarchy, more consistent navigation, and better guidance within the interface.

Finally, the stakes of poor B2B UX deserve emphasis. It has been argued that B2B designers carry a particular responsibility [41] as their decisions affect users across multiple client organizations simultaneously. This study illustrated that consequence concretely: ambiguous language around scheduling and publishing actions had already led to concern for users. These are not the kinds of errors that result in mere frustration, as might be the case in a B2C context, but ones with professional consequences. Experienced users indicated that they had learned to navigate these ambiguities over time, but for novice

users who have not had this opportunity, such ambiguities risk leading to errors. This reinforces the argument that B2B UX is not a lesser counterpart to B2C UX, but a distinct discipline with its own set of priorities and responsibilities.

5.2 Method Critique

By applying RtD [54] and DT [7] insights could be gained about the design of a B2B application, and how this design may differ from that of a B2C application. As discussed in Section 2, there is existing research on B2B systems, however, it primarily focuses on industries other than the media industry. Therefore it is important to learn directly from users of *Media Center*, as a B2B system within the media industry may require different functionalities than B2B or B2C systems in other industries. Due to the exploratory nature of this research, a qualitative approach was deemed most suitable, as it is valuable when one seeks to understand users and their needs [32]. Although the results are specific to the context of this application, they can indicate trends and needs for future research.

It is worth questioning the reliability of the feedback gathered, as participants did not use the application to complete real tasks in its intended context, which means that their assessments of its usefulness remain speculative and may not accurately reflect how they would experience the prototype in practice. Cultural homogeneity among participants further resulted in missed perspectives. As outlined in Section 2, different cultures hold varying attitudes toward usability [9], and given that ClipSource serves a globally diverse customer base, incorporating cross-cultural perspectives would have added considerable depth to the findings.

While semi-structured interviews were deemed the most appropriate method for data gathering, they inherently involve trade-offs, including the tension between covering a broad range of topics at the risk of participant fatigue. In this study, interviews were limited to a maximum of an hour, to reduce risk of fatigue. Semi-structured interviews were used because, although they are time-consuming, they offer several advantages. In particular, their flexibility allows for follow-up questions, enabling the collection of in-depth information [1]. They are especially useful in the early stages of data gathering to establish a foundation, as well as in later stages to collect feedback. However, the interpersonal relationship between the interviewer and the interviewee plays a crucial role in how much the interviewee is willing to share and can also introduce challenges such as social desirability bias [26, 47]. For this reason, it was vital to ensure that participants felt comfortable, were interviewed in a low-stress environment, and understood that the research was conducted independently of ClipSource.

The three prototypes developed for the cognitive walkthrough were implemented as Figma prototypes, which constrained the range of possible interactions. Coded prototypes would have offered a more realistic experience; however, high-fidelity prototypes can lead participants to perceive the design as finalized, potentially limiting the depth of feedback they provide [35]. It would also have been beneficial to involve users in the cognitive walkthroughs rather than employees, who, given their proximity to the product development process, risk introducing bias into their evaluations. While all participating employees demonstrated a critical and open-minded approach to the redesign, the absence of users at every stage of the process remains a limitation.

Several features emerged during data gathering that participants either requested or expressed dissatisfaction with. Nevertheless, not all of these features were implemented. Although they initially appeared promising based on participant suggestions, further investigation revealed that they were not feasible.

Finally, to analyse the results, thematic analysis was used. The robustness of the thematic analysis could have been strengthened had more than one researcher independently coded and reviewed the material, enabling an assessment of whether the identified themes were consistent across analysts. This was not feasible given the volume of data and the constraints on the company supervisor's availability, but it remains a methodological limitation worth acknowledging.

5.3 AI as Design Tool

AI was used in this study as a collaborator in the design process to help develop the best possible solutions to the problem statement. For the initial phase, ChatGPT and Claude were deemed sufficient to brainstorm ideas. This was considered beneficial as the human-AI collaboration could help reduce blind spots [53]. In the later stages, Claude (Github Copilot) was used to iterate between design suggestions and to implement it through code. Using these tools put an emphasis on critical thinking regarding outputs, and strong judgment on which design solutions which may have potential. While this provided valuable first-hand insight, it could have been conducted more systematically, with clearer tracking and testing of different models and techniques. However, this was outside the scope of the current research. As this reflects the perspective of a single individual, gathering additional viewpoints from other design practitioners would have allowed for a more comparative understanding of AI's role in design practice.

In this study, AI was only considered as a tool to support the design process and was not implemented in the interface itself. This was due to the sensitive nature of the data handled within ClipSource's system, which may not be suitable for processing through external AI tools.

Design and Implementation. Overall, the tools proved useful for some aspects of design work. It supported creativity and made the process more efficient. Although an important limitation emerged: they may be better suited for designing from scratch than for replicating and redesigning existing products. When given screenshots and asked for suggestions, the output tends to become an entirely different product, struggling to follow the existing design language and therefore producing solutions that are unfeasible for direct implementation. That said, the tools work well as a brainstorming aid. Ideas can be drawn from the output for inspiration and quickly translated into appropriate suggestions in a tool like Figma. They also performed better when focused on specific elements rather than a whole interface. For example, when asked about *Help*, the suggestions were strong enough to directly inspire the final design. The same was true when exploring how accessibility features, such as color contrast, could be implemented.

The choice of prompting strategy unsurprisingly proved to be one of the most significant factors in determining the effectiveness of AI assistance throughout the design process. Different approaches carried distinct advantages depending on the stage of the project.

Images. In the early stages, pasting images into the models provided a useful starting point, giving AI something concrete to build from. However, without very specified prompts they often produced quite generic designs, ignoring the design language in the image provided.

Descriptive prompting. Writing prompts freely proved useful in early to mid stages, enabling quick progress. However, it was not suitable for later stages of the design and implementation process as it carried the risk of unintended changes occurring elsewhere in the interface, which could easily go unnoticed. As the project progressed and smaller, more precise adjustments were needed, using another AI model to generate prompts proved most effective. Here, the importance of explicitly instructing the

model not to alter anything beyond the specific element being addressed was of value for higher quality results.

Coded prompts. Using Figma Make to generate code from wireframes, and using that code for prompting a specific design, was explored as an additional strategy. The rationale for this was that when only submitting an image, details were often distorted, and it was hypothesised that using HTML/CSS code directly as input would produce more accurate results. While this approach showed some early promise, it quickly became redundant and inefficient, and also led to distorted designs. Initially, the plan was to build in Figma Make and then move the code to another IDE for further refinement and deployment via GitHub, but this proved more difficult than expected. The tool appears better suited for designers who do not intend to work directly with the code. In addition, it requires a large amount of computing power, making the conversion from frames to code very slow. However, the most effective approach turned out to be code-based prompting outside of Figma Make. When implemented in VS Code, copying the relevant code and clearly specifying the desired changes proved to be significantly more efficient.

Models. The choice of model also presented both opportunities and trade-offs. Less powerful models (e.g. Claude Haiku 4.5, Claude Sonnet 4.6 or GPT-5.3-Codex) offer speed, which can be an advantage in the early stages of a project where the priority is to quickly visualise ideas rather than produce polished output. At this stage, most decisions will be revisited anyway, making quality less critical. More powerful models (e.g. Claude Opus 4.1), by contrast, are better equipped to handle complex problems, but longer processing times can disrupt the flow of rapid ideation.

5.4 Ethical considerations

From an ethical perspective, particular attention was given to the handling of sensitive data, especially data related to study participants. Only information directly relevant to the research objectives was collected. All participants were fully informed about the purpose and procedures of the study and were aware that participation is voluntary and that they may withdraw from the study at any time without having to state a reason. Furthermore, all collected data was anonymised to ensure participant privacy, and recordings were deleted after transcription.

From an environmental perspective, it is important to be transparent of AI energy- and water consumption [11]. As mentioned in Section 2, AI can further be biassed or produce misinformation [33, 53]. This puts an emphasis on responsible use of the tool, and always being critical of the material it produces.

5.5 Limitations

As this study focused on a niche user group, professionals working within the media industry, recruiting participants proved challenging. It has been proposed that qualitative studies require no fewer than six participants to reach saturation in a homogeneous group [23], a threshold this study did not meet, which represents a notable limitation. The final evaluation stage had the lowest participation with only three participants, and those who did participate were relatively new to the platform, meaning perspectives from more experienced users were largely absent. Due to participants' limited availability, the final evaluation took the form of a survey rather than a user test, as originally planned. This was not optimal, as deeper insights would have been preferable. On the other hand, the final user interviews help strengthen the survey.

Another limitation concerns the innovativeness of the redesign. The three prototypes were deliberately developed to follow the existing design language of *Media Center*, which may have constrained the design

space explored. A prototype that departed more fundamentally from the current structure could have uncovered alternative approaches to improve the system.

5.6 Future Research

Several directions for future research emerge from this study. First, while this study examined B2B UX design within the media industry, the findings are based on a limited and culturally homogeneous sample of Swedish professionals. Future research should therefore incorporate cross-cultural perspectives, as existing literature suggests that European and North American users, for example, hold differing attitudes toward usability. This would allow for a more comprehensive understanding of how cultural factors shape B2B UX priorities in the media industry specifically.

Second, this study focused primarily on novice to intermediate users, with more experienced users largely absent from the final evaluation. Future research could investigate how highly experienced B2B users interact with redesigned interfaces over time. Longitudinal studies would be particularly valuable here, as they could capture how user perceptions and behaviours evolve as familiarity with the system grows.

Finally, the front-end facing page of *Media Center* was initially planned as part of this study but was excluded due to limited participant recruitment. Future research could explore the relationship between the admin interface and the front-end, and whether a consistent design approach across both is desirable and feasible. This would also open the study to a distinct user group, journalists, whose needs differ considerably from those of media company employees.

6 CONCLUSION

The purpose of this study was to investigate how navigation within ClipSource's *Media Center* can be improved for its B2B users, using AI tools to support the design process.

The findings indicate that users' level of system knowledge shapes how they interact with the platform. Importantly, the study suggests that the needs of novice and advanced users do not necessarily conflict. By restructuring the content hierarchy, reducing pages, and embedding guidance directly in the interface, the redesign was able to support both user groups simultaneously. Furthermore, users within the media industry are generally accustomed to learning new systems. Although guidance was considered necessary, these users display a tolerance for learning curves and often expect a degree of complexity in B2B tools.

The findings also highlight the role of aesthetics in B2B contexts. Participants responded positively to even subtle uses of color and described the current interface as outdated, suggesting that visual design serves a functional role in how users perceive a system.

Regarding AI as a design tool, it proved most valuable in early-stage brainstorming and rapid iteration while showing limitations when tasked with replicating an existing design. The quality of the output was heavily dependent on the prompting strategy, and critical judgment remained essential throughout the process.

In conclusion, this study highlights the importance of embedded guidance (as a complement to organisational support) and considered aesthetics, while also demonstrating that B2B users within the media industry expect a degree of complexity and are accustomed to learning curves. Consequently, a well-structured hierarchy is more important than aiming to minimise complexity.

Future research should investigate how users adapt to the system over time and include larger and more culturally diverse participant groups to strengthen these findings.

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A PRE-INTERVIEW

- What functions would you describe as easy to find?
- What functions would you describe as difficult to find?
- Describe a function (if any) you find frustrating to use.
- Describe the function that is most valuable to you in your work.
- Describe a function you rarely or never use in your work.

B INTERVIEW GUIDE

Primary questions

Introductory question.

- Is there anything you would like me to clarify before we begin?

General questions.

- Can you briefly describe your role?
- When did you first start using Media Center
- How does Media Center fit into your work?
- How often do you use the platform on a weekly basis?

Specific questions.

- Can you walk me through a typical task you perform in Media Center?

- How is your experience navigating the system when performing this task?
- Can you think of a more efficient way to perform this task?
- When searching for information about e.g. The Pitt, similar content can be found in multiple places on the platform (posts, program catalogue, ...), what are your thoughts about that?
- Where do you prefer to search for that information?
- Can you describe the last time you had trouble finding something in Media Center?
- How did you resolve that issue?
- Are there any other situations where you have experienced issues?
- How did you handle those situations?
- How do labels and icons (such as menus and buttons) in Media Center affect your navigation?
- Are they clear?
- What is your favourite feature in Media Center?
- Why do you like this feature?
- Can you describe a feature you feel is not as useful?
- How could this feature be redesigned to be more useful?
- Are there any features you wish existed in Media Center that currently do not?
- Have you seen the tag function?
- Do you feel confident in what the function does?
- Do you use the tag function?
- If so, when and how do you use it?
- When new functionalities are released in Media Center, how are you informed about them?
- Can you think of a better way to receive this information?
- Looking at the interface, what are your initial thoughts?
- Is there anything that stands out to you?
- Can you recall what aspects of Media Center were most difficult to learn?
- In what way could users be supported to make this process easier?
- How well do you think the system supports users with different accessibility needs?

Closing question.

- Is there anything else you would like to add?

C SURVEY

Vilket företag arbetar du på? _____

Hur många års erfarenhet har du av Media Center?

☐ $<$ 1 år

☐ 1 – 5 år

☐ $>$ 5 år

Enligt min mening är prototypen generellt:

☐ Mycket sämre

☐ Sämre

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Bättre

☐ Mycket bättre

Kommentar

_____

_____

_____

För att uppnå mina mål uppfattar jag prototypen som:

☐ Mycket långsammare

☐ Långsammare

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Snabbare

☐ Mycket snabbare

☐ Mycket mer ineffektiv

☐ Mer ineffektiv

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Effektivare

☐ Mycket effektivare

☐ Mycket mer opraktisk

☐ Mer opraktisk

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Mer praktisk

☐ Mycket mer praktisk

☐ Mycket rörigare

☐ Rörigare

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Mer organiserad

☐ Mycket mer organiserad

Kommentar

Enligt min mening, att hantera och använda prototypen är:

☐ Mycket mer oförståeligt

☐ Mer oförståeligt

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Mer förståeligt

☐ Mycket mer förståeligt

☐ Mycket svårare att lära sig

☐ Svårare att lära sig

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Lättare att lära sig

☐ Mycket lättare att lära sig

☐ Mycket mer komplicerad

☐ Mer komplicerad

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Enklare

☐ Mycket enklare

☐ Mycket mer förvirrande

☐ Mer förvirrande

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Tydligare

☐ Mycket tydligare

Kommentar

Enligt min åsikt är prototypens visuella design:

☐ Mycket mindre stilren

☐ Mindre stilren

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Mer stilren

☐ Mycket mer stilren

Kommentar

När det gäller mina personliga krav och preferenser är prototypen:

☐ Mycket mer oflexibel

☐ Mer oflexibel

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Mer flexibel

☐ Mycket mer flexibel

Kommentar

Enligt min åsikt är prototypens användargränssnitt:

☐ Mycket sämre grupperat

☐ Sämre grupperat

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Bättre grupperat

☐ Mycket bättre grupperat

☐ Mycket mer ostrukturerat

☐ Mer ostrukturerat

☐ Samma som original produkten

☐ Mer strukturerat

☐ Mycket mer strukturerat

Kommentar

Avslutning

Här kan du öppet beskriva tankar och åsikter om prototypen. Exempel: Vad tycker du är bra? Vad är mindre bra? Är det något du saknar? etc.

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